Course Requirements

I. Participation 25%

Discussion and active listening will be rewarded; devotion to your phone and frequent absences, not so much. See "Attendance Policy" on page 2 for more details.

II. Short papers 30%

You'll be randomly assigned a letter A, B, or C that corresponds to days on the syllabus, and five times during the semester you will have a short paper due, as marked. These should be about **800 words**; on **primary source readings** assigned for **the day the paper is due**. You are free to analyze the readings according to whatever aspects you find significant, intriguing, or confusing in the context of our course themes, other readings, class discussions, or other things you are currently thinking about. I'm looking for 1) *thoughtful engagement with* and *demonstrated knowledge of* particular aspects of the primary source readings and 2) clear and coherent writing. Although four are assigned, your lowest grade will drop; only your best three papers will count toward your grade. **Please print these papers and bring them to class.**

REMEMBER: Short papers are on **primary sources**, assigned for the day they're due. No late papers will be graded.

Grading Scale:

A+ 100	B 85	C- 71.5	F 55
A 95	B- 81.5	D+ 68.5	
A- 91.5	C+ 78.5	D 65	
B+ 88.5	C 75	D- 61.5	

The rules and procedures of Princeton's Faculty-Student Committee on Discipline are in full effect here. For information on plagiarism and other bad decisions, see http://www.princeton.

III. Bible Spotting 15%

You will need to submit three "Bible Spotting" documents during the semester. These will consist of 1) a link to an example of the appearance of **a specific Bible or Bible verse** in other-than-explicitly-religious American popular culture (in a news story, a song lyric, a movie, whatever) and 2) a very short (less than a page) explanation of what work that use of the Bible is doing. If you can draw connections to our themes or readings, that would be especially great. Your examples must be recent – they must be datable to **after September 1, 2015**. You may email these to me at any time, but be sure to get all three to me on or before **December 10**.

IV. Final Project 30%

For the final project, due on Dean's Date (January 12), your assignment is to write a paper of about 4000 words about either

1) an American Bible. This might be a translation, an edition, or a particular copy. Or,
2) the use of a particular passage of the Bible in America over time.

We'll talk about both options a lot more as we go. What you need to know now is that on **October 29** you'll need to come to class with a brief description of what you're doing and maybe talk a bit about it.

REL 270

The Bible in America

Dr. Seth Perry
sethp@princeton.edu
Rm 245, 1879 Hall
Office Hours: T 12-4
and by appointment

Autumn 2015
T/Th 10:00-10:50
McCosh 2
Th 11:00-11:50
McCosh 24

DEPARTMENT OF RELIGION

The Bible in America

Required Readings

You will need these books:
1) *Piety and Dissent*, Eileen Razzari Elrod
2) *The Civil War as a Theological Crisis*, Mark Noll
3) *How the Bible Works*, Brian Malley
4) *Megillat Esther*, J.T. Waldman
5) *Fundamentalism and American Culture*, George Marsden
6) *An American Bible*, Paul Gutjahr

Also, you will need a bible. It doesn't matter which one, in terms of translation or edition or whatever. It doesn't have to be in English, if you'd rather (and are able to) do the Bible reading for this class in another language. I do ask that you have an actual, physical book, though. You'll probably end up supplementing that book with some of the various Bible web sites and apps and things, for searching, but let's all try to have a physical book to ground our reading. You'll need to bring it to precept on 9-24.

The point of having the bible is for you to look up the biblical passages used in our readings where it seems important to do so.

In addition to these books, there will be many electronic readings; pay attention to each syllabus day and consult Blackboard.

Course Themes

The course will move more or less chronologically, but throughout we'll be working with lenses of analysis that apply over time:

Aesthetics

Materiality

Devotionalism

Hermeneutics

Attendance Policy

I'll assume that if you're not here, it's for a good reason. Please don't provide me with an excuse unless you have something serious going on that will result in multiple absences. Frequent absences will obviously affect your participation grade – there aren't many of you, so if you're not here a lot it'll be pretty obvious. If you absolutely must miss class on a day you have a paper due, email it to me – anything received before the start of class (10:00 a.m.) will be counted as on-time. Anything later than that will not be graded.

Schedule

A, B, C = Short Papers Due

Th 9-17 Introduction
Aesthetics, Materiality, Devotionalism, Hermeneutics

T 9-22 Wait, What's a Bible?
How the Bible Works, 1-72

Th 9-24 No, really, what's a Bible?
How the Bible Works, 73-158

Bring a bible to precept.

T 9-29 Guest Lecture #1
Peter Shultz, Instructor of General Studies, Whitman College

Special Event:
Wednesday, 9-30 at 5:00, location TBA
Vincent Wimbush,
Founding Director, Institute for Signifying Scriptures
"Scripturalization: A Theory of the Politics of Language"

Th 10-1 No Class [sorry]

A T 10-6 The Bible Comes to America A
Mark Christensen, ed., *Translated Christianities*, pp.1-24.
Philip Round, *Removable Type*, chapter 1.
John Eliot, *Indian Dialogues*, 1-24.

B Th 10-8 The American Bible in the 18th Century B
Shalom Goldman, ed., *Hebrew and the Bible in America*, selections.
James P. Byrd, *Sacred Scripture, Sacred War*, chapter 5.
Samuel Seabury, "St. Peter's exhortation to fear God and honor the King" (1777)

C T 10-13 The Bible in the Early-national Period C
Gutjahr chapters 1 & 2
"Petition," Papers of the Continental Congress, v. 41.
Mathew Carey, "Address to the subscribers for the Doway translation of the Vulgate Bible," 1790.

A Th 10-15 The Bible in the Early-national Period A
Thomas Paine, *The Age of Reason*, selections

B T 10-20 Using the Bible in the Early Republic B
Elrod, chapters 1, 2, 3, 5, and 6.

Th 10-22 Guest Lecture
Glenda Goodman, Assistant Professor of Music, University of Pennsylvania

C T 10-27 "The Bible Wars" C
Gutjahr, chapter 4
Primary readings on "the Bible Wars" (*American Catholic History*, 45-57).

Th 10-29 Final Project Discussion: **One-page Descriptions Due**

11-3 & 11-5 No Class – Fall Break

A T 11-10 The Bible and Slavery A
Leonard Black, *The Life and Sufferings of Leonard Black, a Fugitive from Slavery. Written by Himself* (selections).
David Walker, "Our Wretchedness in Consequence of the Preachers of Religion"

B Th 11-12 The Civil War and the Bible B
The Civil War as a Theological Crisis, 1-74
Armstrong, "The Christian Doctrine of Slavery"
Lincoln's Second Inaugural

C T 11-17 The Late 19th Century C
Colleen McDannell, "The Bible in the Victorian Home."
Gutjahr, chapter 5
Ben-Hur (selections)

Th 11-19 The Late 19th Century
Peter Thuesen, *In Discordance with the Scriptures* (selections)
American Judaism and the Bible at the end of the nineteenth century (selections)

T 11-24 The Spirit and the Word
David Kling, *The Bible in History* (selections on Pentecostalism)

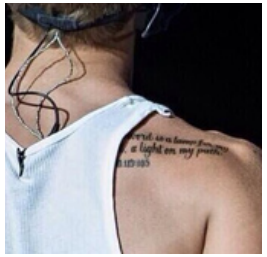
11-26 No Class – Thanksgiving

A T 12-1 Fundamentalism and American Culture A
Marsden 3-101
Azusa Street documents (selections)
Dispensationalism documents

B Th 12-3 Fundamentalism and American Culture B
Marsden 102-138
Fundamentalist-Modernist Controversy documents

C T 12-8 Debating with the Bible in the Post-war Period C
Setzer and Shefferman, eds., *The Bible and American Culture*, 179-197

Th 12-10 The Bible in the 21st Century
Jeremy Stolow, *Orthodox by Design* (selections)
Megillat Esther
Bible-Spotting Selections Due

T 12-15 The Bible and American Popular Culture
Student Selections

Th 12-17 The Bible and American Popular Culture
Student Selections